

The social divide

THE EVENTS IN NEW ZEALAND IN MARCH

were despicable, but they weren't shocking. People have been murdering people for a very long time – long before there was language or even social cohesion. The New Zealand government was quick to ban guns that could be used to mass murder people, and that was a good start, but it's like trying to empty an ocean with a bucket. Many people have had and will have their say about what the root cause of such hatred is, and I suppose this is my version.

As someone who lives in Australia, this event especially dominated the discussions of everyone, everywhere I went. It started with the killer's live stream on Facebook. That video was shared millions of times across platforms, because although most of us are aghast that people want to watch it, let alone share it, the world is weird. More than anything else, what drives most people these days is fomo (fear of missing out). No matter what kind of content something is, if it's trending, everyone wants to consume it. Virality is usually nothing more than a lot of people wanting to fit in with their chosen groups, and have a shared experience.

While video services worked overtime to shut down the cancer from spreading, the memes started. Sadly, that's the state of social discourse today. The Internet is an evil place, and it can bring out the worst in even otherwise good people. The isolation of people when writing comments online makes them drop all inhibitions and delete all filters, and the result is ugly.

Like I said earlier, people have always been this way though, and it was probably evolutionarily advantageous to be xenophobic. After all if you were a family of prehistoric humans, and another family came along, trusting them could very well involve you getting killed or robbed. A little later when society was forming, and groups got considerably bigger, say, the size of a town, xenophobia would have blurred from family groups to much larger groups, but there was always someone new to hate.

This was in decline when it was just mass media who was responsible for information spread. As much as we hate the idea of news corporations dictating what we hear about and what we don't, there was at least accountability placed on the companies of basic human decency. The internet changed that, especially Web 2.0 as it was called. Essentially putting a microphone

and a camera in front of every person's face, and saying "Tell the world what you feel." For decades now I've been telling people that this is just a bad idea, especially when it is coupled with the anonymity of the internet.

If you and I were given a soapbox and told to stand on it in front of our homes, while all our neighbours listened to what we said. We'd probably keep our innermost thoughts (the ones others might find disgusting) to ourselves. The real world has consequences. Online, there seem to be none, especially since you can create a totally fictitious profile and then just spray hatred everywhere.

Studies done by Pew and other research companies over the years have shown that social media, contrary to what we usually believe, actually makes us less sociable, and drives a larger divide in groups than anything else. While this is especially true for politics (a subject I abhor with a passion), it's also true for just about any difference we can imagine.

The Pew study (released in 2017) also found that technology in general was causing this. You can't just blame Facebook or Twitter, it's also search results on YouTube, Netflix, Amazon, or any place that uses algorithms to try and give you more of what we seem to like, thus fuelling our already biased views.

So what can we do about this? We cannot fix the world, we only control ourselves, and we can start by using ourselves as an improvement project. Let's first face the facts. Almost none of us (except the bravest souls) will be deleting all their social media accounts or online accounts anytime soon. It's an evil we need to live with because of all the good things it enables as well. Speaking personally, I've decided to be far more polite online than I've been in the past. This is because hatred breeds hatred, and it always ends in one idiot taking things too far. No matter how much I disagree with a person's views, or how disgusting a human I think they are, I've decided to treat them as if they were sitting on my sofa talking to me while drinking coffee. I don't know if this is idiotic and pointless, but I know that the old ways aren't working. I'd love to hear any suggestions you have, and your tips for dealing with all the negativity we seem to encounter online. Write to me, and let's discuss this as if we were having coffee or tea together. 



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